

ANSHUMAN POYREKAR/GETTY IMAGES

cost of Mumbai's Metro-3 project escalated by Rs 10,000 crore in 2017 when Fadnavis was in charge.

Uddhav finds himself isolated on this plan, though. His idea that BJP-era wrongdoings in the departments of home, water resources and public works be investigated is not eliciting the desired enthusiasm from his colleagues. The Sena does not hold these departments. And the NCP and Congress, the other constituents of the ruling Maharashtra Vikas Aghadi (MVA), believe the CM wants to interfere in their domains using the fight with the BJP as a pretext. At the March 23 meeting, when Thackeray asked his ministers to take a tough stand against the BJP, several senior ministers from the NCP and Congress headed for the exit with the excuse that matters related to their departments were listed in the assembly.

Another part of his war strategy has also come a cropper. An investigation into five extortion cases filed in Mumbai and Thane against Param Bir Singh, the tainted former Mumbai police commissioner, was Thackeray's biggest tool against the BJP. The 1988-batch IPS officer had alleged in March 2020 that former home minister Anil Deshmukh, who's from the NCP, had asked his men to collect Rs 100 crore monthly from Mumbai's bars and restaurants. The BJP had swooped down on Singh's statement to go big rhetorically on the corruption in the MVA government. With Singh's own credibility suspect, it was a risky ploy for the BJP. However, Uddhav lost his leverage when the Supreme Court, on March 22, transferred the investigation in cases against Singh to the CBI.

Now, a fiery attack by Fadnavis, who's currently leader of the opposition, has pushed Uddhav further on the backfoot. In the assembly on March 8, Fadnavis produced videotapes to allege that the MVA has hatched a conspiracy to frame BJP legislator Girish Mahajan in a false scam case. In the tapes, public prosecutor Pravin Chavan is seen saying that he has received instructions from someone in a high position in the MVA to frame Mahajan and other BJP leaders. An embarrassed MVA had to remove Chavan from his post a week later.

A senior NCP minister says the MVA has been too late in acting against the wrongdoings of the Fadnavis regime. "Had we taken action in the first couple of months, the BJP would have been in a great deal of trouble," the minister says. "Now, after two-and-a-half years, any kind of evidence that was there must have been destroyed."

WITH HIS MVA ALLIES COOL TO THE IDEA, CM UDDHAV IS FIGHTING A LONELY BATTLE AGAINST THE RAMPANT BJP

Fadnavis, on his part, is unrelenting in his offensive. He says Uddhav resorted to emotional rhetoric only because he does not have logical answers to his valid questions. He refutes Uddhav's allegation that the BJP only wants to destabilise the government. "We are preparing for the 2024 election. I am confident we will get a full majority," he says. Maharashtra will go to the polls a few months after the general election, but Fadnavis is only being technically correct—the BJP's think-tank is engaged in a different game of perceptions here. According to a top state BJP leader, the party wants to project Uddhav as a second Manmohan Singh, who might be personally clean but has a tendency to shield corrupt ministers and relatives. "If we succeed in establishing him as a helpless leader of fraudsters, it will be half the work done," he says.

Barring his outburst, Uddhav looks composed enough in the face of the crisis facing him, but his inability to protect his men is likely to hit the morale of Sena members. Gajanan Kirtikar, the party's Lok Sabha MP from Mumbai North-Central, recently gave vent to his frustration—the CM may be from the Shiv Sena, but the government belongs to the NCP, he said. That's pretty much consonant with the BJP's line of attack. A warning sign for a Thackeray whose appeal and Achilles heel both reside in the fact that he's not quite Thackeray enough. ■